

SKILLS GUIDE



Excellent verbal and written skills and the ability to understand complex legal language.



Strong problem-solving skills for identifying the best course of action for clients.



The ability to follow detailed legal procedures correctly in order to maintain professional integrity.



Sensitivity for dealing with a range of clients, and the ability to explain legal matters to non-experts.



Dedication and perseverance to press your client's interests from start to finish of a legal case.



CRIMINAL DEFENSE LAWYER

Represents defendants in the criminal court system, offering legal counsel and appearing in court if their client's case goes to trial.



INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY LAWYER

Takes on copyright infringement or intellectual property rights cases for the music, film, news, and publishing industries.



FAMILY PRACTICE LAWYER

Specializes in family-related issues, such as divorce and child custody disputes. May also advise and represent clients who are looking to adopt a child.



ENVIRONMENTAL LAWYER Advises on issues related to the environment, ensuring companies and organizations comply with state and national laws.

RELATED CAREERS

- ▶ **JUDGE** *see pp. 112–113*
- ▶ **ARBITRATOR** Helps resolve legal conflicts outside of the court system. Arbitrators are often retired attorneys. They meet with the disputing parties and assist them in their negotiations.
- ▶ **FORENSIC SCIENCE TECHNICIAN** Collects, analyzes, and reports on evidence found at crime scenes. Many forensic science technicians choose to specialize in either crime scene investigation or laboratory work.
- ▶ **PARALEGAL** Works on legal matters, but is not a lawyer. Paralegals are responsible for many tasks ranging from conducting research and preparing reports to contacting clients and witnesses and gathering and organizing evidence.

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Law • Criminology • English • Psychology • Sociology • History • Business studies • Debating • Research and writing



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS Lawyers must complete an accredited law school program and pass a state's bar exam in order to practice.



LIFESTYLE Lawyers work regular office hours, but evening and weekend work is not uncommon. On-call work can take place any time of day or night.



LOCATION The work is predominantly office-based, but traveling to meet clients, or to attend court proceedings, is a common feature of the job.



THE REALITIES This profession is intellectually demanding, and involves long working hours. Experienced lawyers are very well paid.